INDIA'S DRONE CAPABILITY

The various UAVs with the Indian military



HERON MK-II

Israeli medium-altitude long-endurance UAV for ISR. India has 68 units

COMBAT RADIUS: 3,000 km, endurance of 45 hours

WEAPONS Payload of 470 kg, can carry smaller loitering munitions

TACTICAL USE Carried out deep surveillance into Pakistani airspace pre Operation Sindoor

HAROP

Israeli kamikaze drone (loitering munition). India has 200 of these

COMBAT RADIUS: Range of 200 km, endurance of 6 hours

WEAPONS Carries a 16 kg warhead

TACTICAL USE: Targeted Pakistani air defence radars and installations in Op. Sindoor



SKYSTRIKER

Kamikaze drone/ loitering munition co-produced by India's Alpha Design Technologies and Israel's Elbit Systems. Over 100 units in use

COMBAT RADIUS 100 km

WEAPONS 5-10 kg warhead

TACTICAL USE Used for rapid deployment and precision strikes

HARPY

Israeli kamikaze drone

COMBAT RADIUS: Range of 100 km, endurance of 2 hrs

WEAPONS: Carries a 7 kg warhead

TACTICAL USE: Designed for suppression of enemy air defences (SEAD) role, hit targets in Pakistan

HAWK & SCOUT

Surveillance and early warning drones from Zuppa Geo Navigation Technologies. Over 150 in use

COMBAT RADIUS 1.5 km-2 km

TACTICAL USE: During Op. Sindoor, provided real-time intel up to 2 km into enemy territory

ALS-50 & JM-1

Kamikaze drones from Tata Advanced Systems Ltd and Johnnette Technologies, respectively

COMBAT RADIUS 50 km and 5 km

WEAPONS: Both carry anti-personnel and anti-armour warheads

TACTICAL USE Made combat debut in Op. Sindoor



of drones in modern warfare is now essential to ensure the success of the Indian armed forces. While India acquitted itself well with the limited range but highly precise, expensive and powerful drones, apart from successfully carrying out a range of counter measures to destroy incoming cheap Turkish- and Chinese-made Pakistani UAVs, experts say that there is need for an urgent review of the country's drone warfare capability which was lacking on several fronts. "We can't depend only on expensive platforms. We should fast-track induction of low-cost drones and loitering munitions for mass deployment, build domestic production lines, adapt air-defence and electronic warfare to counter saturation attacks and develop tactics for combined use of high-end and expendable drones," says former Northern Army commander Lt Gen D.S. Hooda.

Given the importance of UAVs on future battlefields, the Indian army is now pushing to integrate them as core force multipliers. Announcing the creation of dedicated drone units, Chief of Army Staff Gen. Upendra Dwivedi has said that the army is "rapidly advancing as a transformed, modern and future-oriented force". As per the plan, the army would require 8,000-10,000 UAVs per corps—the emphasis is on indigenous machines—in its quest to dominate a drone-saturated battlespace. To make this possible, infantry battalions are being restructured: up to 70 soldiers per battalion—each battalion has 900-1,000 soldiers—will form drone teams. These units will be trained in using First Person View (FPV) drones, which provide a first-person perspective through a camera, streamed to a soldier's specialised goggles.

Alongside battalion-level drone platoons, the army is raising specialised formations. Bridging elite and regular